



BEFORE

First Bull Run dwarfed any other clashes that the U.S. Army had hitherto fought. Its use of new technology helped the Confederacy gain advantage.

SMALL ARMIES

Washington had fewer than 17,000 men at Yorktown, the decisive battle of the American Revolution, and General Winfield Scott had taken Mexico City in 1847 with an army of only about 11,000 men. At First Bull Run, Union general McDowell led 35,000 to his opponents' 30,000.

DEVELOPMENT OF RAILROADS

When the British invaded the American colonies, they could not benefit from industrialized forms of transportation, such as the railroad. This **new form of technology** could be used for defensive purposes by both sides in the Civil War.

GEORGE B. McCLELLAN

Shortly before First Bull Run, Union commander George B. McClellan won a few skirmishes in western Virginia, which helped secure the important Baltimore and Ohio Railroad, laying the groundwork for the formation of West Virginia. McClellan's success before the disaster of First Bull Run made him the **natural replacement for McDowell**.

The First Battle of Bull Run took place at the important railroad intersection of Manassas Junction, Virginia. In the wide expanses of the Confederacy, where the primitive road network and the highly dispersed population made it difficult for an army to live off the countryside, railroads were indispensable. They carried much-needed supplies and became strategic assets. The crossing at Manassas Junction, where the Orange and Alexandria Railroad met the Manassas Gap Railroad, was a vital line of communication—leading south into the heart of Virginia, and west to the agriculturally fertile Shenandoah Valley.

The Confederacy posted two field armies to cover these possible lines of advance—General Joseph E. Johnston's force in the northern Shenandoah Valley, numbering a little less than 10,000, and 18,000 men under General P. G. T. Beauregard at Manassas. The Confederate leaders hoped that the railroad in between the two armies would allow them to move reinforcements between both positions more swiftly than the Union army, which did not have access to a direct rail connection.